Parent Understanding of and Involvement in Organized, Out-of-School Youth Activities

Jayson Watkins, McNair Scholar | **Department of Sociology** | **Douglas Hartmann, Ph.D.**

Introduction

The Kids Involvement and Diversity Study (KIDS) project examines the development, accessibility, and impact of organized, out-of-school activities in the Twin Cities. My contribution to the project focuses on parent understanding of and involvement in youth activities and exploring the resources and information available to parents as they make decisions about the activity landscape for their children. Research suggests parental involvement is generally positive, indicating children:

I. Stay out of trouble
II. Achieve greater success in school
III. Develop important life skills and values

Understanding parental involvement, parental pressure, and parental support, as well as youth athletes' perceptions of parent involvement, family tension, and resource allocation, is key to understanding the challenges faced and the rewards experienced by these families (Lindstrom Bremer, 2012).

Methodology

1. Review of Research Literature

A narrative literature review approach used, implementing the following:

- **Search terms**: parenting, guide, youth development, sport, activity/activities, enrichment, hyperparenting, child(ren), and pressure.
- **Databases**: MNCAT Discovery, PsychINFO, GoogleScholar, and LexisNexis.

2. Preliminary Interviews in the Twin Cities Metro

- Interview subjects include parents from a variety of socioeconomic statuses, racial backgrounds, and education levels in the Twin Cities.
- Interviews are recorded, transcribed, and analyzed to identify quotes relating to one of six themes: 1) Differential Treatment, 2) Diversity, 3) Competition, 4) Preparing for the Future, 5) Activity Ethos, and 6) Class and Access.

3. Research on Parental Resources in North Minneapolis

Research on available resources in the Twin Cities that assist parents in choosing activities and programs and to determine the accessibility and availability of such resources.



Source: http://thecityinfluencer.com/wp-content/uploads/2015/02/IMG_7573-2.jpg

Literature Review

Review of the literature on parental involvement in youth activities has yielded three primary insights based on race and class:

Parent Vision on Youth Activities

- Parents want their children to become competent adults displaying values such as kindness, intelligence, responsibility, and awareness. Parents expect activities to influence children to create goals to generate a sense of responsibility to themselves and others (Dunn et al, 2003, Kremer-Sadlik et al., 2010).
- Middle-class families follow the process of "concerted cultivation," where activities provide children with opportunities to showcase skills and talents that will make them successful or meet societal expectations (Lareau, 2003, Vincent & Ball, 2007).

The Importance of Parent Participation in Organized Activities

- Fathers' participation in youth activities is associated with lower rates of persistent criminality for at-risk youth. Active parent participation in youth activities that specifically emphasize education allow for students to become more engaged in activity and schooling (Mahoney & Magnusson, 2001).
- School-based activities are significantly related to the level of home discussions African American parents have with their high school seniors around educational matters. African American parents engage in high levels of discussions with their children who are involved in a school-sponsored activity (O'Bryan et al., 2006).

Nature of Parent Decision-Making and Choice

- Middle-class children participate on an average of 5 activities, while working-class families average 2.4 per child. Middle class families tend to have their children participate in cultural and artistic activities compared to working-class families who participate in sports-related activities (Bennett et al., 2012).
- Since the 1980s, the class gap in activity participation has increased due to: increase in income inequality, "pay to play" activities, and lower funding to public education. This disproportionately affects communities of color whose residents are poorer, less financially stable, and suffer from deficient access to good schools, community facilities, and after-school programs (Hartmann & Manning, 2016, Putnam, 2016, and Snellman et al., 2015).

Parental Views and Values: Preliminary Findings

Preparing for the Future

"People who major in music in college will likely get into almost any med school, because med schools know that they didn't start music the day they started college." *–50-year-old married mother of two*

"It helped her because she has leadership skills. She's able to be a leader. She is not a follower." *–Married Black father of three*

Class and Access

"Sometimes our kids' sports gotta get put on the backburner, we gotta pay bills first, we need a place a stay. We can't just live here for free." *—Married Black father of three*

"One of the main barriers, I won't spend hundreds of dollars on activities, I look for more economic choices. I wish programs and activities could be more user friendly and economic for all." *–44-year-old married mother of three*

"I really have to look for things for them. And sometimes it took me long a time because of the schedule, and the places, if they're too far away. The time, and the money, how much I have to pay. If they offer scholarships or not. I have to see all those things." *–30-year-old Hispanic mother of one*

Limited Community Resources

- Lack of resources available to assist parents in making the right decision based on their family's needs.
- This limitation prevents parents, particularly working class parents, from the following:
  I. Knowing what activities are available to their children
  II. Making informed decisions about which activities to have them participate in
- Schools, community centers, churches, recreation facilities, and the internet should have information available to parents.

Future Research

- Develop a parent resource that includes accessible youth activities in North Minneapolis.
- The parent resource pamphlet will include the following:
  I. Information about the mission and expectation of each activity
  II. Price of each activity and information on need-based scholarships
  III. Contact information for activities
  IV. A map of activities available in the Twin Cities

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http://pclinic.com/stockphotos/bigstock-Tennis-family-standing-in-aro-29812571.jpg

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